requiring that at least thirteen major pieces of Icelandic law be changed, but the Icelandic parliament has now voted to task the civil service with preparing this legislation, a process which is continuing now. I guess there was an issue with Icelandic dignity after the financial meltdown. Their eye was understandably focused on local shocks and many believed the main benefit of the openness haven would be that it would, in future, hold bankers to account, as well as other corrupt Icelandic forces. Down the line, I hope, they will see that transparency could be a real growth industry for Iceland. Strangely, though, for all our lobbying, the journalists were the main opposition: they feared that the new legislation would somehow throw attention away from their own plight, as journalists facing cuts. That was short-sighted, in my view, but you can forgive people for feeling they can't always afford to be idealistic.

The idea of Iceland as a freedom jurisdiction is beautiful. It will raise the country's reputation and a general sense of self-worth. I wonder if Iceland doesn't need something like a prize for freedom of expression, which might do for that little country what the Nobel does for Sweden. The fact that they had the prize, and a society that knew how to live up to the prize, would prove exemplary, and bring the country into focus on the international scene. We worked hard with the parliamentary lawyers and the drafters. I was thinking about the transit towards justice it could bring, this move into scientific journalism, allowing every aspect along the pipeline towards truth to be observed and protected. The effect all over the world would be to have a new high standard to hold up, a standard that said that people could not be prosecuted for seeking to tell the truth. It could be disputed, it could be argued over, but no one would be criminalised for essentially disclosing the truth. I hope it all comes together before too long.

Another issue appeared in spring 2010 that seemed, in the moment, even more pressing. In late 2008 the Icelandic banking system had disintegrated, as the reckless lending of all of Iceland's major banks finally caught up with them. Landsbanki went under in October, threatening €6 billion worth of savings deposited in the bank via their 'Icesave' online accounts by people in the UK and Netherlands. The response of the Icelandic state was that it was not their responsibility, representatives of a tiny and now bankrupt nation, to pay the foreign debts of utterly reckless, private sector banks. The response of the British and Dutch was ruthless. The British chancellor, Alistair Darling, used the provisions of the Anti-terrorism, Crime and